

Liberation Day Volatility: An Analysis of the 2025 Trade War, Geopolitics, and Market Intervention

Executive Summary

This report provides an in-depth analysis of the period of extreme volatility experienced by the U.S. stock market from April to October 2025. This era was defined by a complex interplay of the Trump administration's aggressive trade policies, geopolitical shocks, and direct presidential market intervention, which collectively had a profound impact on global markets. The analysis centers on the market crash triggered by the administration's "Liberation Day" tariff announcement and the subsequent V-shaped recovery driven by the president's controversial social media posts and policy reversals.

The report first explores how the unprecedented tariff imposition, based on the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA), fundamentally altered the market's approach to risk assessment. It then closely examines allegations of market manipulation, focusing on the president's "great time to buy" declaration, by synthesizing the perspectives of legal and financial experts with public sentiment.

Furthermore, the analysis investigates the hypothesis that the public conflict between President Trump and Elon Musk was an intentional "market correction," and assesses the impact of the brief Israel-Iran conflict and the "Triple Witching" options expiration on market volatility.

Finally, the report delves into the formation, application, and limitations of the "Trump Always Chickens Out (TACO)" market theory, a framework developed by market participants to navigate the administration's unpredictable policy patterns. This report concludes that the market turmoil of 2025 had a lasting effect on investor psychology and elevated the importance of political risk analysis to an unprecedented level.

1. The Tariff Shock and the April 2025 Market Crash

1.1 The 'Liberation Day' Proclamation (April 2)

On April 2, 2025, President Donald Trump designated the day "Liberation Day," declaring the U.S. trade deficit a national emergency and invoking the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) to authorize sweeping import tariffs.¹ Framed as "our declaration of economic independence," this action was a continuation of the "Fair and Reciprocal Plan" announced in February and represented the most extreme application of his "America First" trade policy.⁴

The executive order introduced a two-tiered tariff structure:

- **10% Baseline Tariff:** A universal 10% baseline tariff was imposed on imports from nearly all countries, effective April 5.¹
- **Country-Specific Reciprocal Tariffs:** For the 57 countries with which the U.S. had the largest trade deficits, additional country-specific "reciprocal" tariffs ranging from 11% to 50% were scheduled to take effect on April 9.¹ This included a 20% rate for the European Union (EU) and a 34% rate for China.⁶
- These tariffs were in addition to a 25% tariff on imported automobiles effective April 3 and existing Section 232 tariffs on steel and aluminum.¹

While traditional trade policy tools (e.g., Section 232, Section 301) involve predictable processes like investigations and public hearings, invoking the IEEPA—a law designed for emergencies like terrorism or sanctions against specific nations—was a political gamble that redefined the trade deficit as an "unusual and extraordinary threat".³ This allowed the administration to bypass the slower, deliberative procedures of Congress and regulatory bodies, enabling radical policy shifts overnight. For market participants, this compressed the cycle of major policy shocks from months to mere hours, becoming a core driver of the unprecedented volatility that followed.

1.2 Global Market Collapse (April 2–8)

The global market's reaction was immediate and severe. In the hours following the April 2 announcement, U.S. stock futures plummeted, with S&P 500 futures losing 3.9%, Nasdaq 100 futures falling 4.7%, and Dow Jones Industrial Average futures dropping 2.7%.¹

A historic sell-off ensued over the following days. On April 3, the S&P 500 plunged 4.88%, and the Nasdaq Composite suffered its largest-ever point loss, falling 5.97% after dropping over 1,600 points.¹ In just two days (April 3–4), the Dow Jones Industrial Average fell by more than

4,000 points (9.48%), wiping out over **\$6.6 trillion** in market capitalization—the largest two-day loss in history.⁶ The CBOE Volatility Index (VIX), the so-called "fear gauge," spiked 15 points to 45.31, its highest level since the 2020 COVID-19 crash.⁶

While the S&P 500's overall performance for April was a relatively mild -0.76%, this figure masks the extreme intraday volatility.¹⁰ Over a four-day stretch early in the month, the index plummeted **12.4%**, temporarily pushing it into bear market territory (a decline of 20% or more from its peak).¹²

The backdrop to this market collapse was not just the policy announcement itself, but also its pre-emptive economic impact. U.S. GDP for the first quarter of 2025 had already contracted by an annualized -0.3%, driven by a 41% surge in imports as businesses and consumers rushed to make purchases in anticipation of the tariffs.¹³ Because imports are a negative component in GDP calculations, this surge dragged down the economic growth rate. This clearly demonstrated how the mere "threat" of the administration's policies could distort macroeconomic indicators, making it difficult to assess underlying economic fundamentals.

1.3 Reactions by Key Actors

- **Politics (Trump/White House):** President Trump maintained a defiant public stance, stating that events were "going very well" and calling the tariffs "a beautiful thing to behold".¹ Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent warned other nations "do not retaliate".¹ This signaled a willingness to endure market pain to achieve policy goals.
- **China and Europe:** Both powers made it clear they would not capitulate immediately and would retaliate. China announced a 34% retaliatory tariff on April 4 and subsequently escalated its response to match U.S. increases, eventually reaching 125%.⁶ The EU Commission, led by President Ursula von der Leyen, warned that "the global economy will massively suffer" and began preparing countermeasures, stating that "millions of citizens will face higher grocery bills" and medication costs.¹⁶
- **Institutions (Analysts/Media):** Financial institutions like UBS immediately revised their forecasts, warning that the effective U.S. tariff rate could reach 27%, signaling severe economic shock.¹⁸ The market consensus was one of extreme uncertainty and concern over a full-blown trade war.¹⁴
- **The Fed (Powell):** Before the market crash, the Fed was in a wait-and-see mode, holding interest rates at 4.25%-4.5% while monitoring inflation that was running above its 2% target.¹⁹ The tariff shock presented a new dilemma. Tariffs are inherently inflationary, making rate cuts difficult, yet the economic damage they cause would justify rate cuts. These conflicting signals paralyzed the Fed's decision-making process, becoming a major source of added market uncertainty.²⁰

- **Retail Investors:** Investor sentiment froze. The University of Michigan's Consumer Sentiment Index fell to its lowest level since 2020, citing inflation and economic uncertainty.¹³ On April 7, 401(k) trading volume hit its highest level since March 2020, with funds flowing into safe-haven assets like money market funds, indicating extreme risk aversion.⁹

2. The Policy Pivot: Presidential Intervention and Allegations of Market Manipulation

2.1 The April 9 Reversal: A Perfectly Timed Intervention

With the market still in turmoil on the morning of April 9, President Trump sent a direct message to the markets via his social media platform, Truth Social. At 9:33 a.m., he wrote, "BE COOL! Everything is going to work out well." Just four minutes later, at 9:37 a.m., he posted, "THIS IS A GREAT TIME TO BUY!!! DJT".²²

Less than four hours later, at 1:18 p.m., President Trump abruptly announced a **90-day suspension** of the higher-rate reciprocal tariffs for most countries, excluding China.² While the baseline 10% tariff remained, the most significant threat—rates soaring up to 50%—was temporarily removed.

The market's reaction was explosive. The S&P 500 surged **9.5%** that day, its third-best day since 1940, recovering approximately \$4 trillion in market capitalization.¹² It was a moment where the very architect of the crisis personally delivered the resolution, dramatically reversing the market's direction.

2.2 The Manipulation Controversy

The extremely short interval between President Trump's posts and the policy announcement immediately sparked widespread allegations of market manipulation. Critics, including former White House ethics lawyer Richard Painter, noted that securities laws prohibit trading on inside information or helping others to profit from it.²³ The central question was: Did Trump

already know he would suspend the tariffs when he encouraged people to buy stocks?

When asked about the timing of his decision, Trump gave a vague answer: "I would say this morning... Over the last few days, I've been thinking about it... Fairly early this morning".²³ The White House officially defended the post as the president's duty to "reassure the markets and Americans" against "nonstop media fearmongering".²³

The "DJT" signature at the end of the post further fueled the controversy. While Trump often used his initials to emphasize a personal message, "DJT" is also the stock ticker for Trump Media & Technology Group, which owns Truth Social. Regardless of intent, DJT stock skyrocketed **22.67%** that day—more than double the market's gain. This surge was estimated to have increased the value of Trump's personal stake in the company by approximately \$415 million in a single day.²³

This sequence of events demonstrated a new strategy of converting policy uncertainty into direct market leverage. The pattern of creating a crisis (tariffs), hinting at a solution (the "buy" signal), and then delivering that solution (the suspension) resembled a classic manipulation playbook. Regardless of potential legal action, it established a new precedent where the president could function simultaneously as both the primary source of market volatility and its relief.

2.3 The May Rally: Diplomacy, Deals, and AI

The April 9 tariff suspension acted as a catalyst for a powerful rally that continued throughout May. The S&P 500 turned positive for the year on May 13⁶, and for the month, the S&P 500 and Nasdaq gained 6.2% and 9.6%, respectively, marking their best monthly performance since November 2023.²⁸

The key drivers of this rally were:

- **U.S.-China Tariff Truce (May 12):** A specific agreement announced on May 12 and effective May 14 was crucial. For 90 days, the U.S. mutually reduced its punitive tariff rate on China from 125% to an effective 10% level, and China lowered its rate on U.S. goods to 10%.³ This signaled a sharp de-escalation of the trade war.
- **Trump's Middle East Tour:** President Trump's "dealmaking tour" of the Middle East in May added fuel to the rally.²⁸ The tour resulted in the announcement of large-scale deals in technology, particularly in artificial intelligence (AI). For example, Nvidia (NVDA) shares rose after news broke that it would supply semiconductors to Humain, a new Saudi Arabian AI startup.²⁷
- **A Shift in Narrative:** The tour successfully shifted the market's focus from the negative

trade war narrative to a positive, forward-looking technology narrative. Concrete deals, like the one involving Nvidia, provided tangible evidence for this new narrative, reigniting the "AI trade" and lifting technology stocks and the broader market.²⁸

After the initial panic, retail investors, encouraged by the tariff suspension and the strong performance of tech stocks, began to view the dip as a buying opportunity.⁹

3. Geopolitical Tremors and Q2 Market Instability

3.1 The Trump-Musk Feud: A Manufactured Crisis or a Real Clash? (June 5–10)

On June 5, the conflict ignited when Elon Musk, once a Trump ally, publicly criticized Trump's key tax and budget legislation (the "One Big Beautiful Bill Act") as a "disgusting abomination".³⁴

The dispute escalated into a public war of words between the two titans on social media. Trump expressed his "disappointment," while Musk retorted that Trump would have lost the election without his help.³⁴ The conflict peaked when Trump threatened to terminate government contracts with Musk's companies, such as SpaceX.³⁷

The feud had a direct and severe impact on Tesla (TSLA) stock. On June 5, Tesla shares plummeted by more than 14%, wiping out approximately **\$150 billion** in market capitalization in a single day. It was the stock's largest one-day drop in over a year.³⁴

However, the conflict de-escalated as quickly as it had begun. The tone softened starting June 6, and by June 10, Musk posted a conciliatory tweet, effectively ending the public spat.³⁵ The timing of the incident—occurring at a market peak and resolving rapidly—fueled conspiracy theories among retail investors and some analysts that it was a staged fight to induce a "healthy correction" in an overheated market, particularly in the tech sector. The conflict served as a case study in how a "narrative war" between two individuals with massive social media followings could create a targeted volatility event for a specific stock and sector.

3.2 The Israel-Iran Conflict (June 12–21)

The market was hit with another shock after the closing bell on June 12, when news broke that Israel had launched a surprise attack on Iran's nuclear facilities.⁴¹

The market's reaction on June 13 was chaotic. It opened with a gap down but saw a partial recovery during the morning as investors assessed the situation. However, selling pressure intensified again after news emerged that Iran had launched retaliatory drone and missile strikes, leading to a sharp decline into the close.⁴³ The Dow Jones Industrial Average fell by more than 700 points.⁴³ Defense stocks like Lockheed Martin (LMT) surged, while airline and travel-related stocks plunged.⁴²

On June 19, President Trump issued a two-week ultimatum for Iran to negotiate, implying that the U.S. military could attack if they failed to comply.⁴⁵ When Iran did not respond within the deadline, the U.S. directly struck three Iranian nuclear facilities (Fordow, Natanz, and Isfahan) on June 21-22 under the codename "Operation Midnight Hammer".⁴⁷ The operation involved B-2 stealth bombers and submarine-launched Tomahawk missiles.⁴⁷ The conflict was brought to a close with a ceasefire announced on June 24-25.⁴⁹

3.3 'Triple Witching' as a Volatility Catalyst (June 20)

June 20 was a "Triple Witching" day, when stock index futures, stock index options, and individual stock options expire simultaneously. The total value of options expiring on this day was approximately **\$6.5 trillion**.⁵¹

A prevailing theory for the market's relative calm during the initial phase of the Iran crisis was the existence of large call option positions concentrated at specific strike prices (e.g., S&P 500 at 6,000). This concentration was believed to have created a "pinning effect," where the index was tethered to a specific price range as market makers hedged their gamma and vanna exposures.

On June 20, as these massive options positions expired, the market's artificial shackles were released. The significant market decline on that day was attributed to the disappearance of this "pinning effect," allowing the suppressed geopolitical risk of the Iran conflict to be fully priced into the market. This phenomenon clearly illustrated how technical market structures can distort and delay the pricing of fundamental risks. The geopolitical risk had not vanished; it had merely been contained, only to be released in an explosive burst.

4. The 'TACO' Doctrine: Deciphering the Cycle of Threats and Retreats

4.1 The Rise of a Market Theory: "Trump Always Chickens Out"

The term "TACO (Trump Always Chickens Out)" was first coined on May 2, 2025, by *Financial Times* columnist Robert Armstrong.⁵³ The acronym summarized a market observation: President Trump repeatedly followed a pattern of making extreme tariff threats that caused market downturns, only to eventually walk them back or delay them, allowing the market to rebound.⁵³

This theory led to a specific investment strategy known as the "TACO trade": buying on the dip when Trump's tariff threats caused stock prices to fall, and then selling for a profit on the rebound, anticipating the inevitable policy retreat. This pattern conditioned investors to discount the administration's hardline rhetoric rather than taking it at face value.⁵³

When asked about the "TACO" moniker, President Trump dismissed it, replying, "it's called negotiation".⁵³ This highlighted the gap between the market's cynical interpretation and the administration's official stance. In essence, the TACO doctrine can be seen as a behavioral finance phenomenon where investors, through repeated exposure, become desensitized to a specific type of political risk, treating threats not as policy signals but as contrarian buying opportunities.

4.2 The Summer of TACO: The Tariff Tug-of-War in July-August

The administration's tariff-related actions over the summer further reinforced the TACO narrative.

- The reciprocal tariff suspension, originally set to expire on July 9, was extended to August 1.⁵⁷
- President Trump threatened specific tariffs against South Korea and Japan (July 10), as well as Canada (35%) and Brazil (50%).³
- Crucially, the 90-day tariff truce with China, set to expire on August 12, was extended for another 90 days to November 10.⁵⁸ This event strongly confirmed for market participants that the TACO pattern remained valid.

4.3 The Final Test: The October Tariff Threat Against China

On October 10, citing China's export controls on rare earth minerals, President Trump posted on Truth Social that he was considering a "massive increase of tariffs on Chinese products,"

later specifying a **100% tariff** to be imposed from November 1.⁶²

Even a market accustomed to the TACO theory reacted with extreme fear to the sheer scale of this threat. The S&P 500 plunged 2.7% and the Nasdaq fell 3.6%, marking their worst day since April.⁶³ The sell-off wiped \$770 billion from the market capitalization of tech giants in a single day.

However, the TACO pattern held true once again. The administration immediately began to soften its tone. By October 12, President Trump was reaffirming plans to meet with President Xi Jinping and speaking of a good relationship with China, adding that a 100% tariff was not a "sustainable" level.⁶⁵ This rapid de-escalation triggered a sharp market rebound on October 13, perfectly demonstrating a classic TACO trade.⁶⁵

But this pattern contained a dangerous feedback loop. As the market increasingly priced in a "chicken out" scenario, the effectiveness of the threats diminished. This created a situation where the administration had to issue ever more extreme threats (e.g., 100% tariffs) to elicit the desired market reaction. This, in turn, increased the risk of a policy misstep where the administration could not back down without losing credibility—a "TACO trap" where the market's learned behavior could lead to its own undoing.

Conclusion and Outlook

The period from April to October 2025 will be remembered as the time when the Trump administration transformed trade policy into a real-time market management tool. The tariff shock using the IEEPA, the controversial market intervention on April 9, the targeted volatility created through the conflict with Musk, and the cycle of threats and retreats embodied by the "TACO" doctrine are all evidence of this new paradigm.

This period left several important legacies for the market. First, the political risk premium has permanently risen, as the perception grew that every presidential utterance could serve as a direct trading signal. Second, investors became more focused on deciphering the psychology of policymakers than on the substance of policy, making the market more cynical and headline-driven. Third, while fundamental analysis remains important, all market participants came to realize the overwhelming influence of political variables in predicting short-term market direction. The experience of 2025 will continue to shape how markets assess and price political uncertainty for years to come.

Appendix: Timeline of Key Events (April–October 2025)

Date	Politics (Trump, White House, etc.)	Institutions (Financial Institutions, Media, etc.)	The Fed (Powell, Fed Governors, etc.)	China	Europe	Retail Investors
4/2	"Liberation Day" declared, IEEPA invoked. Announces 10% universal tariff from 4/5 and country-specific reciprocal tariffs (up to 50%) from 4/9. ¹	Major media like Bloomberg and CNBC report on tariff shock, warning of worsening investor sentiment and potential recession. ¹	Concerns over stagflation (inflation + recession) due to tariffs. Faces a policy dilemma. ²¹	Strongly opposes unilateral U.S. action and signals retaliatory measures. ⁶	EU deeply regrets the U.S. decision and announces it will prepare countermeasures. ¹⁶	Extreme fear spreads, leading to widespread panic selling. ⁶
4/3-4/8	Trump: "Going very well," "a beautiful thing to behold," dismissing market	S&P 500 plunges 4.88% (4/3). \$6.6 trillion in market value evaporates	Deepens deliberation on monetary policy direction amid conflicting signals	Announces 34% retaliatory tariff (4/4). Later matches U.S. escalation	EU begins preparing a list of retaliatory tariffs. Von der Leyen warns of	Consumer sentiment plummets. Large-scale shift of 401(k)

	crash. Sec. Bessent urges against retaliation. ¹	es in two days. VIX index soars. ¹	of inflationary pressure and economic slowdown. ¹⁸	n to 84% (4/9). ⁶	immense damage to the world economy. ⁸	funds from stocks to bonds/MFs. ⁹
4/9	Trump tweets "THIS IS A GREAT TIME TO BUY!!!" at 9:37 AM. At 1:18 PM, announces 90-day suspension of reciprocal tariffs for countries other than China. ²³	S&P 500 soars 9.5%, its 3rd best day since 1940. Allegations of market manipulation arise. ¹²	Monitors the sharp market rebound. Increased uncertainty regarding interest rate policy decisions.	Welcomes the U.S. tariff suspension but calls for negotiations to resolve underlying issues.	Welcomes the tariff suspension, seeing it as an opening for negotiations. Suspends its own countermeasures for 90 days. ⁸	Attempts to buy the dip following the president's signal. Controversy and interest in the DJT stock surge. ²⁶
Around 4/20	Expresses satisfaction with the stock market rise, promoting it as a result of his	Market stabilizes. S&P 500 recovers most of its early April losses, with a strong tech-led	Relieved by market stability but maintains a stance of monitoring inflation	Maintains negotiation channels with the U.S., attempting to reach a substantive	Prepares for trade negotiations with the U.S., coordinating positions on key issues like auto	Relieved by the market rebound. Begins to form a belief in the "Buy the Dip" (BTD) strategy,

	policies.	rebound. ¹²	indicator s.	agreeme nt during the suspensi on period.	tariffs.	learning from the "V-shape d recovery. "
5/12	Announc es a 90-day tariff suspensi on agreeme nt with China, citing progress in trade negotiati ons. ³	Positively assesses the U.S.-Chin a tariff truce. S&P 500 turns positive for the year the next day (5/13). ⁶	Reduced global economic uncertain ty from easing U.S.-Chin a tensions reinforce s the case for keeping interest rates on hold.	In line with the agreeme nt, lowers its retaliator y tariff rate to 10% and removes some non-tariff barriers. ³⁰	Views the U.S.-Chin a agreeme nt positively , with hopes for a more stable global trade environm ent.	Improved investor sentimen t due to reduced U.S.-Chin a risk. Increase d investme nt in tech and AI-relate d stocks. ²⁸
Mid-May	Trump tours the Middle East, announci ng large-sca le tech/AI investme nt deals with Saudi Arabia and others. Mentions "the most	Tech stocks like Nvidia surge on news of AI investme nts from the Middle East. The market narrative shifts from trade	Monitors the tech-led market rally, remainin g vigilant about potential asset price bubbles.	Wary of expandin g U.S. influence in the Middle East, viewing it as competiti on for its Belt and Road Initiative.	Expresse s general support for stability and economic cooperati on in the Middle East.	"Stock party" atmosph ere. Actively buys tech stocks following the president 's social media "leads." ²⁸

	impactful and important " event.³²	wars to AI.²⁷				
6/5-6/10	Trump and Musk engage in a fierce public dispute over a tax bill. Trump threatens to cancel government contracts with Musk's companies.³⁴	Tesla stock plummets 14% (6/5), losing \$150B in market cap. Market correction conspiracy theories spread.³⁴	Monitors the risk of a specific corporate dispute spilling over into the broader market.	U.S.-China working-level trade talks proceed (6/9-10). Progress is viewed positively. [User Query]		Conspiracy theories spread among retail investors about a "staged fight for a healthy correction." [User Query]
6/12-6/13		Futures market drops sharply after-hours on news of Israel's attack on Iran. Extreme volatility after the market opens on the 13th.⁴¹	Middle East geopolitical risk surges. Concerns about renewed inflationary pressure from a spike in oil prices.⁴²			Buys on the dip after the initial drop on the 13th, then incurs losses on the subsequent decline. Partially hedges with defense

						stocks (LMT). [User Query]
6/19-6/21	Trump issues a 2-week ultimatum to Iran (6/19). U.S. military then strikes 3 Iranian nuclear facilities (6/21). ⁴⁵	\$6.5 trillion "Triple Witching" day (6/20). Expiration of options removes "pinning effect," unleashing volatility. Stocks fall sharply. [User Query]	Market volatility is maximized as geopolitical risks and technical factors converge. Closely monitoring the situation.			Expects a full-blown bear market to begin after the options expiration, believing war-related risks are now being priced in. [User Query]
Early July	Extends the tariff suspension, set to expire on 7/9, to 8/1. Threatens a return to April-level tariffs if no deal is reached. ⁵⁷	Market fatigue grows as the administration's "brinkmanship" repeats. The "TACO" theory gains traction. ⁵⁵	Analyzes the negative impact of recurring trade policy uncertainty on business investment and sentiment.			Discusses investment strategies based on the "TACO" theory. Prefers holding cash over selling during tariff

						threats. [User Query]
7/10-7/11	Threatens specific high tariffs on South Korea/Japan, Canada (35%), and Brazil (50%). ³					Strong backlash from Brazil and other targeted nations.
8/12	Announces another 90-day extension of the tariff truce with China, pushing the deadline to November 10. ⁵⁸	Market reacts as if the outcome was already expected, reaffirming the TACO theory.		China is relieved to have more time for negotiations and seeks to reset its long-term economic relationship with the U.S.		Believes the TACO pattern is proven once again, confirming the validity of not selling on threats.
10/10-10/13	Trump threatens 100% tariffs on China in response to rare earth	S&P 500 plunges 2.7% on the 100% tariff threat (10/10). Rebound	Internal review of the impact of extreme policy volatility on	Criticizes Trump's threat as the "wrong approach" and calls for		Views this as the most dramatic example of the TACO theory,

	controls (10/10). Shifts to a conciliatory tone, mentioning a meeting with Xi (10/12). ⁶³	s sharply on the conciliatory gesture (10/13). ⁶⁴	financial stability.	dialogue. ⁶⁷		seizing short-term trading opportunities amid extreme volatility.
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